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DISENFRANCHISED GRIEF IN HISTORICAL AND CULTURAL PERSPECTIVE

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Every concept has a biography or a history of how that concept was born, developed, and matured. The concept of disenfranchised grief began in a graduate seminar on aging that I was teaching early in the 1980s. As we were exploring widowhood in later life, one of my students, a middle-aged woman, remarked: "If you think widows have it rough, you ought to see what happens when your ex-spouse dies." I was intrigued by her comment, and I asked her if she would share her experiences. She did. She had been divorced. Two years after her divorce, her ex-husband died of cancer. The divorce had been angry and painful; she had caught him having an affair with a neighbor whom she had viewed as a friend. She spoke of the awkward experiences in visiting her ex-husband at the hospital and attending his subsequent funeral. The woman found little support as she struggled with her ambivalence and grief in the aftermath of that death. They had been divorced, her friends and family surmised, so why would she feel grief? Some friends even ventured that it was a sweet revenge. She noted that she had to take vacation days to attend the funeral because her workplace bereavement policies offered leave only for present spouses—not past ones.

Although it was compelling enough in itself, her narrative resonated with me for another reason. I had been asked to present a paper at a Foundation of

Thanatology Conference in New York on "Unsanctioned and Unrecognized Grief." I had been casting about for an idea. I now had one.

As I researched the loss of an ex-spouse, I found a number of items of interest. First, although intensity of reactions varied, all individuals in the small samples I found did experience some form of grief reaction. Second, all noted that the lack of social support for their losses—both the divorce and the subsequent death—was a complicating factor in their ability to adapt to the loss.

After completing that paper, I decided to continue researching losses that were unacknowledged and unrecognized by others. I reasoned that if a lover in an extramarital affair dies, the grief of the surviving lover might well be unrecognized or unacknowledged. Because it was difficult to locate a large enough sample, I decided to expand the research into individuals, heterosexual or homosexual, who had any significant dyadic relationship outside of marriage. This included couples living together, couples dating but not cohabiting, and even engaged people whose partners had died. Again, the results were similar. As the individuals recounted their stories, they noted that they had suffered a significant loss but, as one gay man mentioned, "had no right to grieve." As I emphasized that latter point in my presentation, participants at the conference shared with me their own stories about losses where they had "no right to grieve." I realized there that I had touched a common chord in these very different situations of loss, and in 1985 I presented a conceptual paper on what I called *disenfranchised grief*.

In that paper (Doka, 1985b), I defined disenfranchised grief as grief that results when a person experiences a significant loss and the resultant grief is not openly acknowledged, socially validated, or publicly mourned. In short, although the individual is experiencing a grief reaction, there is no social recognition that the person has a right to grieve or a claim for social sympathy or support.

THE DISENFRANCHISEMENT OF GRIEF

The concept of disenfranchised grief integrates psychological, biological, and sociological perspectives on grief and loss. Since the middle of the 20th century, considerable research has examined psychological, biological, and physiological responses to loss (see, e.g., Bowlby, 1980; Lindemann, 1944; Parkes & Weiss, 1983). This research has demonstrated the myriad affective, physical, cognitive, behavioral, and spiritual ways grief is manifested.

The social aspect of grief often is neglected, however. Although an individual may have an intense and multifaceted reaction to loss, that loss and the ensuing responses may be unacknowledged by surrounding others or the society at large. Although the individual grieves, others do not acknowledge that he

or she has a right to grieve. Such persons are not offered the “rights” or the “grieving role,” such as a claim to social sympathy and support or compensations such as time off from work or diminishment of social responsibilities.

To understand the social aspect of grief, it is important to remember that every society has norms that govern not only behavior but also affect and cognition. Hochschild (1979), for example, wrote of “feeling rules” or norms that govern what individuals are supposed to feel in a given situation (see also chap. 4, this volume). Statements such as “I know I should not feel guilty” or “I have every right to feel angry” bear testimony to the reality of these feeling rules. These statements justify feelings on the basis of shared understandings or what feelings are to be expected in a given social context. Similarly, there are “thinking rules” that govern how one is supposed to think in a given situation. Again, statements such as “How can you think like that?” imply that an individual’s cognitions are outside a society’s range of acceptability or understanding of logic and reason. Similarly, there are “spiritual rules.” These rules tell people what to believe. For example, in some religions one might be expected to believe that expressions of grief are inappropriate because the deceased has entered a wonderful afterlife.

As part of these rules, every society has norms that frame grieving. These norms include not only expected behaviors but also feeling, thinking, and spiritual rules. These grieving rules govern what losses one grieves, how one grieves them, who legitimately can grieve the loss, and how and to whom others respond with sympathy and support. These norms exist not only as *folkways*, or informally expected behaviors, but also as *laws*, meaning that these norms may carry sanctions. For example, these norms are evidenced in company policies that extend bereavement leave to certain individuals as well as regulations and laws that define what family member or other person has control of the deceased’s body or funeral rituals. In the United States and many other Western societies, these grieving rules emphasize that family members have a right to grieve the deaths of other family members. When a family member dies, one is allowed and expected to grieve, often in a specified way. Family members then are accorded rights such as time off from work, diminished social responsibilities, and social support.

Yet human beings exist in *intimate networks*, associations that include both kin and non-kin. Individuals experience a range of losses that are not death related. Divorce, or the relinquishment of a child in adoption or foster care, is an example of non-death-related loss that can arouse grief. In addition, humans form attachments with a wide range of individuals—friends, coworkers, clergy, coaches, therapists, physicians and other health care workers, clients, and patients, to name just a few. Human attachments go beyond relationships even with other humans. We form attachments to celebrities, even if we have never met them (see chap. 12, this volume). We bond with animal companions. Even possessions can take on great significance and meaning in our

lives. One of the most profound cases of grief I ever encountered was a woman who lost Christmas ornaments collected over a period of 400 years, family heirlooms, in the Red River Floods in North Dakota in the mid 1990s.

In such situations, the personal experience of grief is discordant with the society's grieving rules. The person experiences a loss, but others do not recognize that grief. The person's losses may fall outside of a society's grieving rules and may be disenfranchised to a degree. However, the central question—why is grief disenfranchised?—remains. Why are only deaths of family members accorded social recognition and support?

There are probably a number of reasons for this. First and foremost, in most Western societies, the family is the primary unit of social organization. Hence, kin ties have clear acknowledgment in norms and laws. Although most individuals actually live their lives in the intimate networks mentioned previously, only kin have legal standing.

Kamerman (1993) described a latent function of these grieving rules. They strengthen the traditional family by denying recognition of other relationships, outside of the family, especially socially unsanctioned relationships, such as lovers or unmarried partners, that might weaken the primacy of family relationship. Kamerman also suggested that perhaps there is a limited reservoir of social support. If the circle of grievers or the circumstances of grief were enlarged, then less support might be available to the immediate family survivors of a death.

Another principle of contemporary Western societies has been *rationality*. That is, beyond the family, organizations such as businesses attempt to organize work policies in fair, functional, and rational ways, and grieving roles reflect that. As Kamerman (1993) observed, to extend grieving roles to nondeath situations or to non-kin would create organizational burdens. Organizations would be forced to define *levels of friendship* or *types of loss*. They might be required to broaden the concept of bereavement leave, at considerable cost. Acknowledging the death of kin alone makes organizational sense. It recognizes the grief of kin when a family member dies, at least symbolically. Limiting the acknowledgment of loss to family members avoids confusion and potential abuse, affirming a single rational standard. This keeps organizations from having to assess, from an individual standpoint, whether this loss or relationship is entitled to recognition. These policies reflect and project societal recognition and support, again reaffirming and sanctioning familial relationship.

They also point to another significant factor: the relationship of grieving rules to ritual. As an interpsychic process, *mourning* refers to the ways that grief is socially acknowledged, for example, accepted behaviors, such as mourning dress, that signify that an individual has experienced a loss. Rituals that connote loss are critical to mourning. These rituals allow structure and support to the expression of grief. For example, Durkheim (1915) claimed that "mourning is not a natural movement of private feelings; it is a duty imposed by the

group. One weeps, not simply because he is sad, but because he is forced to weep" (p. 443).

Durkheim, in justifying the critical importance of social norms, exaggerated. Yet he did contribute a central point: Social expectations frame the experience of grief.

Pine (1989) stressed the critical role that funerals have in enfranchising grief. The funeral becomes the vehicle by which grief is acknowledged and sanctioned and the locale where support is extended. The primacy of a family at the funeral reaffirms that these survivors have experienced a loss and that their subsequent grief needs sanction, acknowledgment, and support. The rite of the funeral publicly testifies to and affirms the right to grieve.

Of course, other factors influence grieving rules and thereby affect disenfranchisement. For example, the culture of counseling (see T. Martin & Doka, 1999; Sue & Sue, 1999) emphasizes affect. Persons who grieve in other ways may be accorded less than full recognition or support for their grief. Societies, too, may consider certain types of death as punitive, anxiety provoking, or embarrassing, and thus withhold full support (Doka, 1989; Rando, 1993; see chap. 10, this volume).

D. Martin (2005) developed this further in his analysis of the role of blame in offering support to parents whose children were murdered. Martin noted that grief was legitimated only when the lives of victims were considered beyond reproach. When the victim was seen as engaging in activities that were criminal or self-destructive, social support and sympathy were withheld. Often this is connected to an individual victim or mourner's status within the social structure. In cases of individuals of lower income, there was often an attribution of blame, such as that the individual had little reason to be where, or with whom, he or she was. In such cases, police often took a highly inquisitive, rather than supportive, stance with families as they notified the family about the death. Think as well, for example, of someone who dies of lung cancer. Often, the first question asked is whether the deceased individual smoked. Implicit in this question is a possible assumption that such a person bears responsibility for his or her illness.

Naturally, in a diverse society even losses disenfranchised by society as a whole may be acknowledged within a smaller subculture. For example, the death of a gay lover in many societies may not be fully recognized by family or coworkers, but the grieving lover may be recognized and supported within the gay community (Eyetsemitan, 1998). Then, too, grieving rules can differ among subcultural groups, whether defined by class, ethnicity, or another organizing factor (see Doka & Davidson, 1998; Eyetsemitan, 1998). Thus, subcultures may mitigate the sense of disenfranchisement. Two implications follow.

The first implication is that grieving rules differ between cultures. What is disenfranchised in one culture may be supported in another. For example, in some cultures, gay relationships are highly proscribed. In other cultures,

such as those of the Netherlands, Canada, or some states in the United States, homosexual marriages or domestic partnerships are fully legal. Obviously, differential levels of social support can be expected in these distinct societies at the death of a gay partner.

Cultural norms may affect the process of grieving in other ways as well. In some cultures, certain ways of grieving may be understood as valid expressions of grief, whereas in other cultures the same behaviors may be disdained as excessive or inappropriate. Similarly, certain types of relationships might be acknowledged in some cultures but ignored in others. In Italian and Hispanic cultures, godparents are accorded great importance. Whether family or non-family members are selected, they are recognized as having a significant role in the life of a godchild. Should one's godchild or godparent die, grief would be expected. In other Christian cultures, such a role may have only symbolic importance, one primarily limited to the time of the godchild's baptism. In other cultures, with different faith systems, such relationships may not even exist. These are just some examples of how grieving rules differ across cultures, redefining for every culture what types of losses are in fact disenfranchised (see also chap. 10, this volume).

Cultures, of course, change. Eyetsemitan (1998) noted that these grieving rules may change over time. Younger cohorts, for example, may be more supportive than older people of the loss of a partner in an unmarried cohabiting couple; they may also be more supportive than their older counterparts of losses within a homosexual relationship. In the United States, there has been a growing awareness of certain losses, such as perinatal loss (at least for the mother), that is now evidenced by the appearance of greeting cards that console mothers for such a loss. Similarly, other cards have recently appeared acknowledging other losses as well, such as the loss of a pet.

The second implication is that there is recognition of degrees of support. In most Western societies, when friends, coworkers, colleagues, neighbors, or even celebrities and political and cultural leaders die, individuals may be expected both to show a display of grief and even possibly engage in mourning behaviors—attending the funeral, sending flowers or a contribution, and otherwise supporting the family. However, they are not accorded the full rights given to family grievers, such as an extended leave, diminished social responsibility, and extensive social sympathy and support. In fact, they may be expected to convey support to the family. The nature of disenfranchised grief is that the attachment to the deceased and the grief experienced by non-kin may not be accorded commensurate recognition and support by the larger society.

The discussion so far has emphasized the sociological aspects of disenfranchised grief yet, as Kauffman (2002) stressed, there is an intrapsychic dimension to disenfranchised grief as well. These societal grieving rules are internalized. The rules become standards by which we assess and judge the legitimacy of our own grief reactions. Thus, disenfranchisement is not only

imposed by the society but also can be self-initiated, such as when shame and guilt over one's own attachments and subsequent grief may define a particular grief reaction as inappropriate or unworthy and the griever thus disenfranchises his or her own reactions to the loss.

Neimeyer and Jordan (2002) contributed a term that integrates the societal and intrapsychic dimensions of disenfranchised grief while offering a clinically important concept for assessing and treating this grief. To Neimeyer and Jordan (2002), the essential issue in disenfranchised grief is *empathic failure*, defined as "the failure of one part of the system to understand the meaning and experience of another" (p. 96). Here there is a failure to understand any given individual's personal experience or meaning construct of a particular loss and therefore a failure to render sufficient sympathy and support.

Empathic failure can take place at a very basic level—the interface between self-experience and self-interpretation. This would refer to Kauffman's (2002) intrapsychic dimension of disenfranchised grief. Neimeyer and Jordan (2002) offered the example of a mother of a child with significant disabilities who struggles with the intense ambivalent emotions that frame her grief reaction to her son's death. Empathic failure can occur at the level of family and intimate network as persons in the immediate surround fail to acknowledge and support another's grief. It also can take place within the larger community, where there is little recognition or validation of support. It can even involve a sense of spiritual alienation whereby an individual mourner feels separated from his or her own sense of spirituality or divinity as he or she copes with loss. The role of counselors, then, is to analyze and counter this empathic failure.

The sources and reasons for disenfranchised grief, then, are diverse and multifaceted. Yet, the results are the same: An individual experiences a loss that is not socially sanctioned, publicly acknowledged, or openly mourned.

TYPES OF DISENFRANCHISED GRIEF

Which losses are disenfranchised? In my 1989 book *Disenfranchised Grief: Recognizing Hidden Sorrow* (Doka, 1989), I suggested three broad categories of loss and implied a fourth. These categories were developed inductively and clinically; that is, certain types of cases suggested a series of broad categories. In 1989, I proposed the following.

The Relationship Is Not Recognized

As stated earlier, in U.S. society most attention is placed on kin-based relationships and roles. Grief may be disenfranchised in situations in which the relationship between the bereaved and deceased is not based on recognizable kin ties. Here the closeness of other non-kin relationships may

simply not be understood or appreciated. For example, Folta and Deck (1976) noted that

while all of these studies tell us that grief is a normal phenomenon, the intensity of which corresponds to the closeness of the relationship, they fail to take this (i.e., friendship) into account. The underlying assumption is that closeness of relationships exists only among spouses and/or immediate kin. (p. 239)

The roles of lovers, friends, neighbors, foster parents, colleagues, in-laws, step-parents and stepchildren, caregivers, counselors, coworkers, and roommates (e.g., in nursing homes) may be long lasting and intensely interactive, but even though these relationships are recognized, mourners may not have full opportunity to publicly grieve a loss. At most, they might be expected to support and assist family members. This is especially true for formal or professional caregivers. As Moss, Moss, Rubinstein, and Black (2003) noted, many nursing homes view the facility in an almost familial way, but despite the strong metaphors of family that are often used, staff members' grief when a resident died was in many ways disenfranchised.

Research has added nuances to the study of relationships that are disenfranchised. For example, places such as prisons can disenfranchise even socially legitimated relationships. Both Ferszt (2002) and Olson and McEwen (2004) have found that grief is often disenfranchised in the prison system when a loved one dies on the outside. Even if the role is acknowledged as significant (e.g., a parent), participation in rituals may be inhibited and sympathy withheld partially out of security concerns and because the prisoner may not be regarded as worthy of support (see D. Martin, 2005). Both studies (Ferszt, 2002, and Olson & McEwen, 2004) found the concept of disenfranchised grief to be a useful interpretive tool.

There has been little research on the effects of newer technologies, such as the Internet, on the experience of grief (see chap. 12, this volume). Although thanatologists have explored the role of the Internet in grief education and support (see chap. 26, this volume; T. Martin & Doka, 1999), the effect of the Internet on grief has been largely ignored. Yet many individuals maintain extensive contacts on the Internet, interacting with a range of individuals, developing Web-based friendships and sharing intimacies. In such cases, the only indication of a loss may be unanswered e-mail or a cryptic "host unknown." The Internet is likely to spawn grief as well as to inform and support grievers.

There also are relationships that may not be publicly recognized or socially sanctioned. For example, some nontraditional relationships, such as extra-marital affairs, have, at least in many cultures, tenuous public acceptance and limited legal standing and face negative sanction within the larger community. Individuals involved in such relationships are touched by grief when the relationship is terminated by the death of the partner. Others in their world,

such as children, may also experience a grief that cannot be acknowledged or socially supported.

Even persons whose relationships existed primarily in the past may experience grief. Ex-spouses, past lovers, or former friends may have limited contact, or they may even engage in interaction in the present. Yet the death of that significant other can still cause a grief reaction because it brings finality to that earlier loss, ending any remaining contact or fantasy of reconciliation or reinvolvement. The grief over the death of an ex-spouse may be experienced not only by the surviving spouse but also by others in the family system, such as surviving children or even ex-in-laws. They too may mourn the loss of what once was and what might have been. For example, in one case, a 12-year-old child of an unwed mother, who had never even been acknowledged or seen by the father, still mourned the death of his father because it ended any possibility of a future liaison. However, although loss is experienced, society as a whole may not perceive that the loss of a past relationship could or should cause reaction.

The Loss Is Not Acknowledged

In other cases, the loss is not socially defined as significant. For example, some people may not perceive the loss of an animal as a cause for intense grief. Nevertheless, research (e.g., Kay, Nieburg, Kutscher, Grey, & Fudin, 1984) has shown strong ties between pets and humans and profound reactions to loss.

In some cases, the reality of the loss itself is not socially validated. Thanatologists have long recognized that significant losses can occur even when the object of the loss remains physically alive. Sudnow (1967) for example, discussed *social death*, in which the person is alive but is treated as if dead. Examples may include persons who are institutionalized or comatose. Similarly, *psychological death* has been defined as conditions in which the person lacks a consciousness of existence (Kalish, 1966), such as someone who is brain dead. One can also speak of *psychosocial death*, in which the persona of someone has changed so significantly, through mental illness, organic brain syndromes, or even significant personal transformation (e.g., through addiction, religious conversion, Alzheimer's disease and related dementias), that significant others perceive the person as he or she previously existed as dead (Doka, 1985a). In all of these cases, spouses and others may experience a profound sense of loss, but that loss cannot be publicly acknowledged because the person is still biologically alive.

Rando (2000), in her exemplary work on anticipatory mourning, explored the range of losses that persons experience and mourn in life-threatening illness. Rando made the point that individuals do not simply mourn the fact that they or someone they love has a terminal disease and will one day die. Although that is part of their grief, they mourn as well all the losses experienced along

the way. I remember one friend whose husband died of amyotrophic lateral sclerosis, a motor neuron disease. She told me once that even worse than the death was the loss of his ability to speak. She grieved their inability to communicate, to discuss the affairs of life—once such a vital part of their relationship. In the same way, the secondary losses that follow a death, such as changes in lifestyle of other relationships, may also be mourned.

In the years since this concept of disenfranchised grief was proffered, the category of unacknowledged loss has generated much of the research that has focused on disenfranchised grief. Studies have applied the concept of disenfranchised grief to the reactions of the loss of romantic relationships in adolescence (Kaczmarek & Backlund, 1991) and young adults (Robak & Weitzman, 1995); grief responses to reproductive (Gray & Lassance, 2003) and perinatal losses (Hazen, 2003); and reactions to the experiences of incest (Dwyer & Miller, 1996), disability (Sapey, 2004), job loss (Leana & Feldman, 1992), or growing up in a dysfunctional family (Zupanick, 1994). In addition, the concept has been applied to the grief process of cultural reentry (Lester, 2000). It has even been used to understand the effects of the Great Irish Hunger (1846–1852) as a cultural grief reaction experienced by the descendents of that Irish diaspora (Peck, 2000). Berra et al. (1993) documented how the loss of a religious identity due to changes in belief created a sense of grief in many respondents. Yet much of this research has been primarily descriptive, documenting a type of loss and using the term *disenfranchised grief* in a descriptive way by explaining that many persons who identified this loss experienced limited social support. With the exception of Corr (1998), Eyetsemitan (1998), and Kamerman (1993), little work has offered critical analysis that either challenged or expanded the concept.

The Griever Is Excluded

There are situations in which the characteristics of the bereaved in effect disenfranchise their grief. Here the person is not socially defined as capable of grief; therefore, there is little or no social recognition of his or her sense of loss or need to mourn. Despite evidence to the contrary, others typically perceive both the old and the very young as having little comprehension of, or reaction to, the death of a significant other. Often, then, both young children and older adults are excluded from both discussions and rituals (Raphael, 1983).

Similarly, persons with intellectual disabilities may also be disenfranchised in grief. Although persons with intellectual disabilities are able to understand the concept of death (Lipe-Goodson & Goebel, 1983) and, in fact, experience grief (Edgerton, Bollinger, & Herr, 1984), others may not recognize or know how to manage the grief of a person with intellectual or other mental disabilities (Clements, Focht-New, & Faulkner, 2004; McEvoy & Smith, 2005). Over time, two additional categories were added, described in the sections that follow.

Circumstances of the Death

In my 1989 book (Doka, 1989), I suggested that certain circumstances surrounding the death might disenfranchise grief. The nature of the death may constrain the solicitation of the bereaved for support as well as limit the support extended by others. For example, many survivors of a suicide loss often feel a sense of stigma, believing that others may negatively judge the family because of the suicide. Similarly, the stigma of AIDS may lead survivors of an AIDS-related loss to be circumspect in sharing the loss with others (see Doka, 1993). Here, survivors may fear the responses of others including isolation, judgment, or a morbid curiosity.

Rando (1993) further developed this idea. She asserted that deaths that provoke anxiety (e.g., suicide, mutilating loss, the death of a child) or embarrassment (e.g., death from autoerotic asphyxiation or homicides, especially those that incur media notoriety or involve other family members) are likely to cause disenfranchised grief. Other circumstances that minimize support may be those in which support is withheld punitively (e.g., when an individual is executed) or where the deceased is otherwise devalued (e.g., the death of an alcoholic).

The Ways an Individual Grieves

The way an individual grieves also can contribute to disenfranchisement. T. Martin and Doka (1999) suggested that there are different styles of grieving. Some individuals grieve in a more intuitive way, experiencing and expressing grief as deep feeling. Those who are more instrumental experience and express grief reactions in a way that is more physical, cognitive, or behavioral. The counseling community tends to disenfranchise instrumental grievers because counselors often place a high value on affective response (see T. Martin & Doka, 1999; Sue & Sue, 1999). The larger community disenfranchises instrumental grievers early in the grieving process, when affective displays are expected, and intuitive grievers later in the grieving process, when affective responses are considered less appropriate (T. Martin & Doka, 1999). Certain cultural modes of expressing grief, such as stoicism or wailing, may fall beyond the grieving rules of a given society and thus can be disenfranchising (Doka & Davidson, 1998).

Alternate Typologies

These examples and categories are meant to illustrate the many ways grief may be disenfranchised. They are not exhaustive; neither are they exclusive. An individual's grief may be disenfranchised for a number of these reasons. For example, a foster parent experiencing the death of a HIV-positive foster child may see grief disenfranchised because the foster parent relationship may not be validated and the disease stigmatized within his or her community.

Also, of course, this particular taxonomy draws on examples attuned to contemporary Western culture. In other cultures, the relationships not recognized, losses not acknowledged, grievers excluded, circumstances under which an individual dies, or how a person grieves—all the factors that disenfranchise grief—may differ.

Neither is this the only taxonomy of disenfranchised grief. Corr (1998) offered another way to categorize disenfranchised grief. Corr approached classification deductively, asking “What is disenfranchised in grief?” He concluded that the state of bereavement, the experience of grief, and the process of mourning can all be disenfranchised.

These taxonomies assist in understanding two facets of disenfranchised grief: They (a) further contribute to an analysis of the reasons why grief is disenfranchised and (b) delineate the types of losses and situations that can create disenfranchisement, thus furthering application and research.

DISENFRANCHISED GRIEF AS A COMPLICATING FACTOR

Disenfranchised grief has been identified as a complicating factor in bereavement (see Rando, 1993). The problem of disenfranchised grief can be expressed in a paradox: The nature of disenfranchised grief creates additional problems for grief, while removing or minimizing sources of support.

Disenfranchised grief may exacerbate the problem of bereavement in a number of ways. First, the situations that often result in disenfranchised grief tend to intensify emotional reactions. Although each of the situations described is in its own way unique, the literature uniformly reports how each of these disenfranchising circumstances can intensify feelings of anger, guilt, or powerlessness (see, e.g., Doka, 1985a, 1986, 1987; Geis, Fuller, & Rush, 1986; Kelly, 1977; Miller & Roll, 1985; Peppers & Knapp, 1980).

Second, both ambivalent relationships and concurrent crises have been identified in the literature as conditions that complicate grief (Rando, 1993; Raphael, 1983; Worden, 1982). These conditions can often exist in many types of disenfranchised grief. For example, studies have indicated the ambivalence that can exist in cases of abortion (Raphael, 1983), among ex-spouses (Doka, 1986; Scott, 1985), among significant others in nontraditional roles (Doka, 1987; Horn, 1979), and among families of individuals with Alzheimer’s disease (Doka, 1985a). Similarly, the literature documents the many kinds of concurrent crises that can trouble the disenfranchised griever. For example, in cases of cohabiting couples, either heterosexual or homosexual, studies have often found that survivors may experience legal and financial problems regarding inheritance, ownership, credit, or leases (e.g., Doka, 1987; Horn, 1979; Kimmel, 1978, 1979). Likewise, the death of a parent may leave a person with a mental disability not only bereaved but also bereft of a viable support system (Edgerton et al., 1984).

Disenfranchised grief is complicated, and many of the factors that facilitate mourning are not present. In death-related losses, the bereaved may be excluded from an active role in caring for the dying. Funeral rituals, normally helpful in resolving grief, may not help here. In some cases, the bereaved may be excluded from attendance. In other cases, they may have no role in planning those rituals or in deciding whether even to have them. Or in cases of divorce, separation or psychosocial death, rituals may be lacking altogether.

In addition, the nature of the disenfranchised grief precludes social support. Often there is no recognized role in which mourners can assert the right to mourn and thus receive such support. Grief may have to remain private. Although the bereaved may have experienced an intense loss, they may not be given time off from work, have the opportunity to verbalize the loss, or receive the expressions of sympathy and support characteristic of a death. Even traditional sources of solace, such as religion, are unavailable to those whose relationships (e.g., extramarital, cohabiting, homosexual, divorced) or acts (e.g., abortion) may be condemned within that faith tradition.

COUNSELING DISENFRANCHISED GRIEVERS

The complications often experienced by the person disenfranchised in his or her grief reinforce Neimeyer and Jordan's (2002) concept of empathic failure. Their approach to counseling persons who are experiencing disenfranchised grief is to begin by assessing this empathic failure. Among the questions they suggested therapists consider are queries that attempt to assess where empathic disconnection occurs. How much does an individual contribute to his or her own disenfranchisement? Does an individual isolate him- or herself or shroud a loss in secrecy or deception, thereby minimizing support? Do the norms and values of the individual's family or community censure certain behaviors or relationships limiting support? Does an individual's spirituality create a sense of spiritual alienation? Does disenfranchisement seem to occur at any particular time in the mourning process; for example, do many mourners experience a sense of support early in the grieving process that dissipates over time? The concept of disenfranchised grief should not be reduced to a typology. Neimeyer and Jordan emphasized that the clinical importance of the concept is that it offers the clinician a lens through which to understand the support that a client does or does not receive from others as he or she copes with grief.

Once an assessment is made, empathic failure can be countered. Sometimes, the very naming of the grief as disenfranchised has power, breaking the silence around the loss and offering a sense of legitimacy (Kuhn, 2002). As Neimeyer and Jordan (2002) stressed, disenfranchised grief is grief—the techniques that one would use in counseling persons who are grieving can be applied here. Evidence indicates that support groups are a useful strategy (Olson & McEwen, 2004; Pesek, 2002). Because rituals are often unavailable

or limited in meaning to persons experiencing disenfranchised grief, I have suggested the value of using therapeutic rituals within the counseling process (Doka, 2002). The very act of counseling is valued because it offers support and validation that might not be provided elsewhere.

IMPLICATIONS AND CONCLUSION

Despite the shortage of critical and analytical research on and attention given to the issue of disenfranchised grief, it remains a significant and growing issue. Millions of individuals are involved in losses in which grief is effectively disenfranchised. There are estimates that 3% of men and 2% to 3% of women are exclusively homosexual, with similar percentages having mixed homosexual and heterosexual encounters (Gagnon, 1977). Approximately 1 million abortions are performed each year; even though many of the women involved may not experience grief reactions, some are clearly at risk. As individuals continue to live longer, more will suffer from severe forms of chronic brain dysfunctions. As the persons with developmental disabilities live longer, they too will experience the grief of parental and sibling loss. In short, the proportion of disenfranchised grievers in the general population will rise rapidly in the future.

It is likely that bereavement counselors will have increased exposure to cases of disenfranchised grief. In fact, the very nature of disenfranchised grief and the unavailability of informal support make it likely that those who experience such losses will seek formal supports. Professionals in the field of death education also need to consider the many kinds of relationships and subsequent losses that people can experience.

In many ways, the work on disenfranchised grief has been part of a larger challenge to the ways that we understand loss. It certainly has led to an increased sensitivity to the many situations and circumstances that create loss and evoke grief. Yet there is a danger here that it may broaden the concept of loss so widely that grief is trivialized and support lessened. This is Kamerman's (1993) caution: How can we offer support to every person affected by each circumstance of loss?

Many years ago, I spoke at a conference about disenfranchised grief. After the presentation, I met an old childhood friend, now a clinician. He had moved in his early adolescence, and we had had no contact since that time. He jokingly reminded me of an incident in which his baseball glove had been stolen. He remembered that I had stayed and sympathized with him over his loss. "I was," he claimed, "your first case of disenfranchised grief."

As the myriad circumstances of loss become more recognized, there is a pressing need for research that really describes the particular and unique responses to different types of losses; compares reactions, outcomes, and problems associated with these losses; assesses possible interventions; and describes

the critical variables that affect each loss. One clear benefit of the concept of disenfranchised grief has been a heuristic value that has, in fact, encouraged research on many situations of loss or has evaluated the viability of the concept of disenfranchised grief for understanding different types of loss (chap. 21, this volume; Dwyer & Miller, 1996; Ferszt, 2002; Hazen, 2003; Kaczmarek & Backlund, 1991; Lester, 2000; Moss et al., 2003; Olson & McEwen, 2004; Peck, 2000; Robak & Weitzman, 1995; Sapey, 2004; Thornton & Zanich, 2002; Zupanick, 1994). However, as mentioned earlier, more research is clearly needed. This research needs to go beyond simply describing the experiences of varied losses that seem to engender reactions typified as disenfranchised grief. Instead, this research should provide a base on which to assess the ways grief reactions vary among different types of losses regarding the intensity of reactions as well as the process and outcomes of grief. Such research will expand our understanding of grief and avoid trivializing loss and, most critically, it will offer a background to acknowledge, assist, and enfranchise the disenfranchised.

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